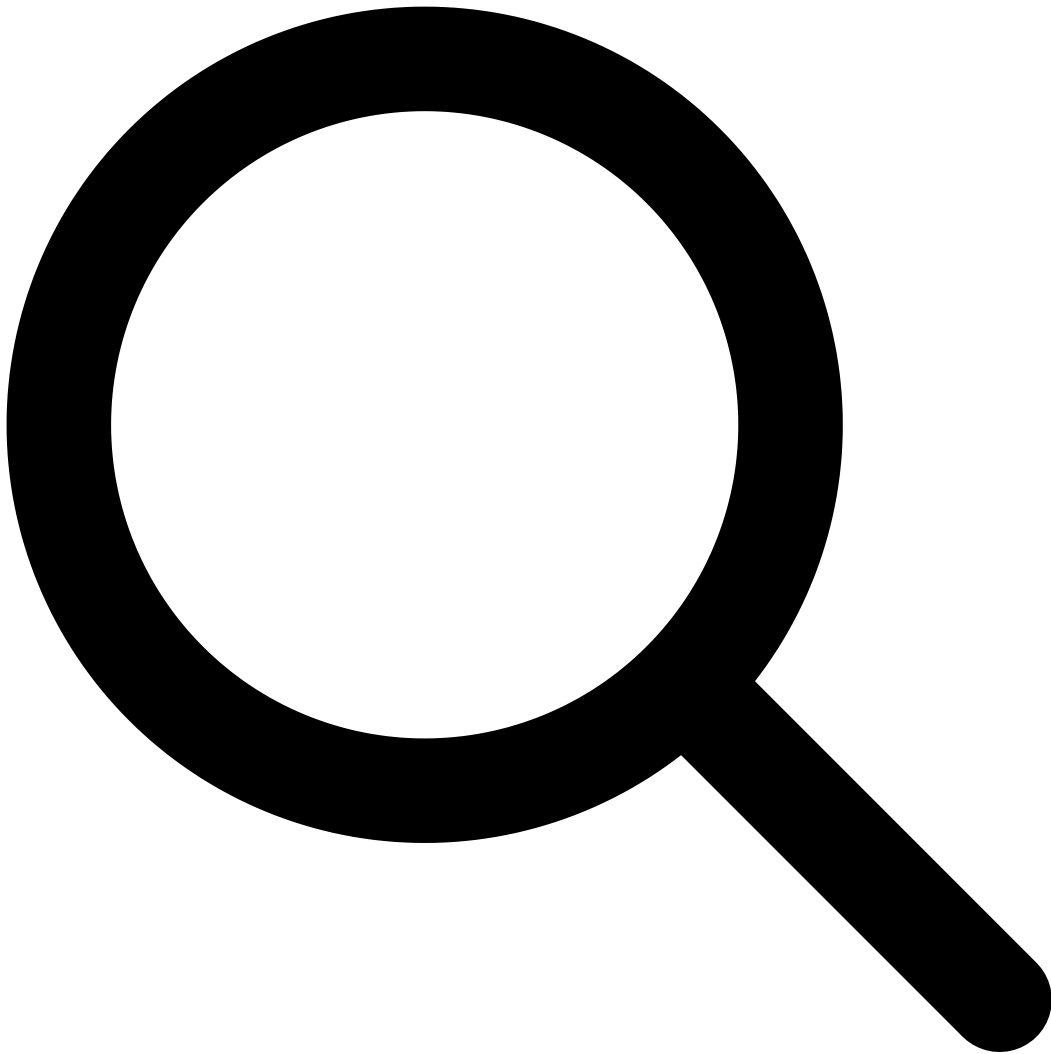


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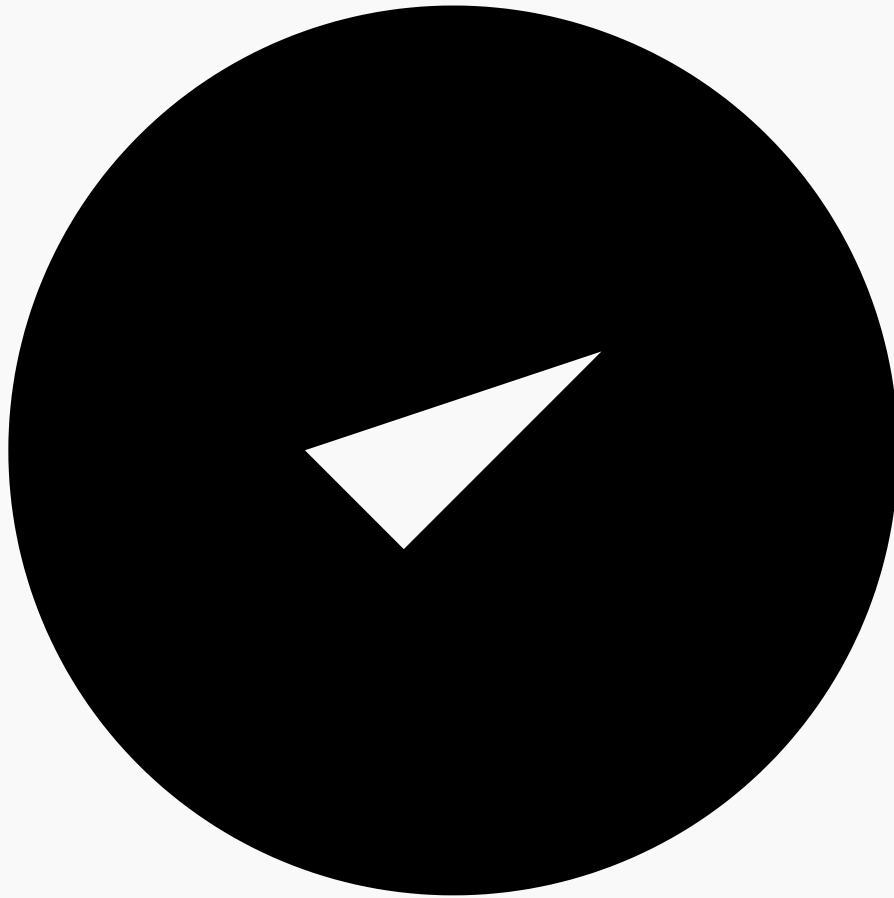
[Trevor Lam \(/\)](#)

QSR

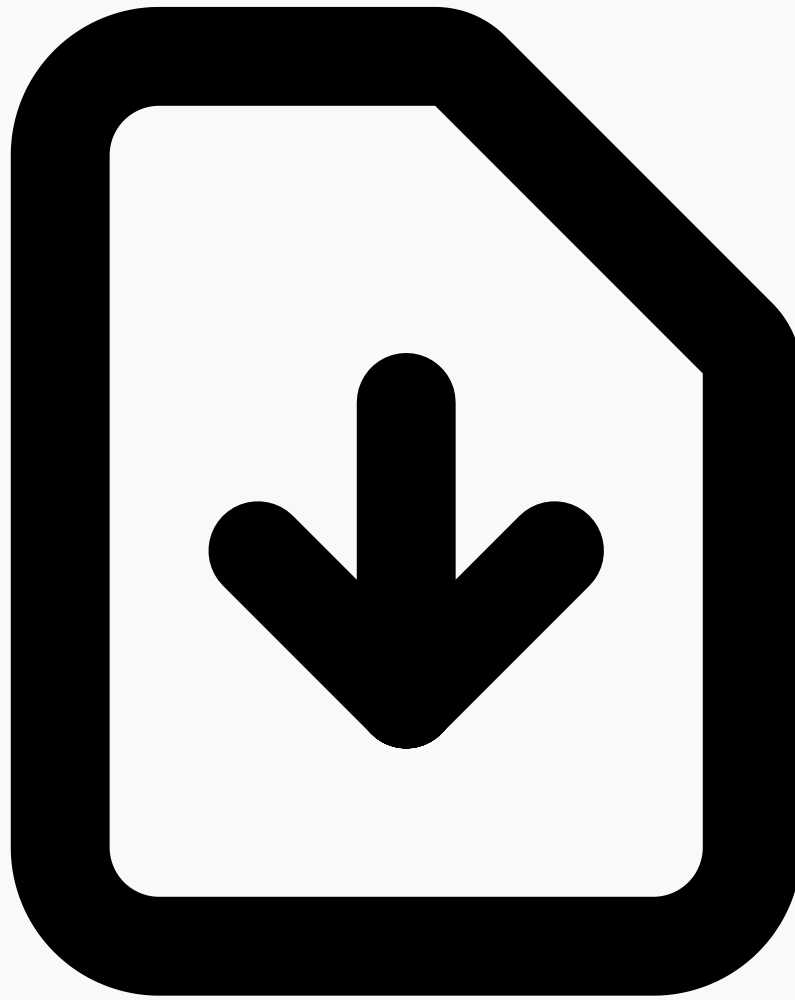
Revitalizing Unit Performance: Driving Revenue from \$1.4M to \$1.7M at Sonic



Last updated: January 14, 2024



Case verified



Sonic Drive-in (D.L. Rogers Group): Revitalizing Unit Performance

Operational Context

In 2016, I assumed leadership of a Sonic Drive-in unit with significant untapped potential. Within 18 months, the unit's performance had been completely revitalized, moving from bottom-tier to top 10% in company KPIs.

My path over 12 years: Carhop → Crew Leader/Traveling Trainer → Assistant Manager → Co-Manager/AMLC Instructor → Operating Partner/General Manager (2016-2020)

Starting Point (2016)

- **Revenue:** \$1.4M at unit with untapped potential
- **Food Cost Variance:** 2.7% (unsustainable)
- **Labor Cost Variance:** 3.9%
- **Employee Turnover:** 175%+ (industry average: 130-150%)
- **KPI Performance:** Bottom tier
- **Up to 40 employees** under management responsibility

The Revitalization Methodology

Ground-level observation → Leading by example → Standards reinforcement → Deliberate personnel triage prioritized by:

1. Guest impact first
2. Culture second
3. Procedure third

Phase 1: Food Cost System Redesign

Implemented education-first approach with daily KPI conversations:

- Systematic waste log analysis
- Portion control enforcement
- Spoilage tracking
- Theft pattern identification
- Accuracy standards reinforcement
- Performance-based reward (free meals) tied directly to improvement

Result: Food cost variance reduced from 2.7% to 0.75%

Phase 2: Workforce Optimization

I built elastic staffing models myself—didn't delegate this:

- Disciplined scheduling
- Demand forecasting
- Pre-quit behavioral signal identification
- Proactive retention interventions

Result: Employee turnover reduced from 175%+ to under 80% — approximately 100 percentage point reduction

Phase 3: Multi-Site Influence (Traveling Trainer)

Certified operational standards across 7 **locations** with:

- Formal pass/fail assessment authority
- Gap analysis and corrective planning
- Influence without direct authority

Phase 4: Organizational Recognition (AMLC Instructor)

I was selected as the **youngest and first Co-Manager in company history** to become an AMLC Instructor:

- Delivered formal management curriculum to classes of 30-50 students
- “Talent recognized from above” — not just curriculum delivery

The Outcome

Quantitative Results

- **Revenue:** \$1.4M → \$1.7M (~21% growth)
- **Sales:** 10%+ over budget
- **Profit:** 5%+ over budget
- **Food Cost Variance:** 2.7% → 0.75%
- **Labor Cost Variance:** 3.9% → -0.25%
- **Employee Turnover:** 175%+ → under 80%
- **KPI Performance:** Top 10% of company

Recognition: Three Consecutive Annual Awards

- **Rookie of the Year (2016)**
- **Revitalization Operator of the Year (2017)**
- **Culture of Respect Award (2018)**

The COVID Exit — Strategic Intelligence Signal

I left in November 2020 at my peak:

- Top 10% KPIs company-wide
- Three consecutive awards
- Youngest AMLC Instructor in organizational history
- **Eight months into COVID**, when restaurant industry faced most severe structural contraction in modern history
- **Declined Dallas partnership offer** specifically to pursue university degree

I read the room correctly—the restaurant industry was about to crater. Leaving at the top wasn't failure; it was knowing when to exit. That's the judgment you want in operations leadership.

Confirmed Additional Scope

- Bank deposits and petty cash/change fund controls (zero-discrepancy)
- Safety and incident documentation (workers' comp, OSHA-adjacent)
- Equipment and facilities vendor management
- Staff scheduling (built personally, not delegated)
- Inventory ordering and management (direct daily practice)
- Full ownership: payroll, recruiting, interviewing, onboarding, performance management, vendor relations, billing, local store marketing, community outreach, food safety compliance

Skills Demonstrated

- **P&L Management:** Full ownership of \$1.4M→\$1.7M unit revitalization
- **Operational Revitalization:** Transforming underperforming unit to top 10% performer
- **People Operations:** 100 percentage point turnover reduction
- **Multi-Site Training:** 7-location certification with pass/fail authority
- **Curriculum Development:** AMLC Instructor (youngest in org history)
- **Cost Control:** Food cost 2.7%→0.75%, labor cost 3.9%→-0.25%

What This Role Proved

Over 12 years, I showed I can:

- Drive operational revitalization and performance improvement
- Earn three consecutive awards across different evaluation dimensions
- Achieve youngest-in-history organizational recognition
- Exit at peak performance rather than ride decline
- Apply same promotion mechanism at every level: finish work ahead of pace, explicitly request more responsibility, earn advancement based on demonstrated quality
- Build zero-discrepancy financial controls (daily deposits, petty cash, change funds)

These aren't lucky breaks. It's the same pattern—arrive, diagnose, optimize, repeat—across three industries where I had zero prior technical knowledge.

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Available for Operations, Chief of Staff, and HR/Payroll opportunities.

[LinkedIn](https://linkedin.com/in/trevor-lam) (https://linkedin.com/in/trevor-lam) [Email](mailto:trevor@trevor-lam.com) (mailto:trevor@trevor-lam.com)